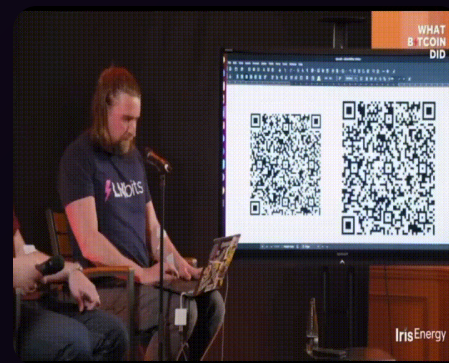


Building without permission in the age of AI

About me

BUILDER, EDUCATOR, TINKERER, CEO LNbits.COM NOSTR.COM



A brief history of free and open-source

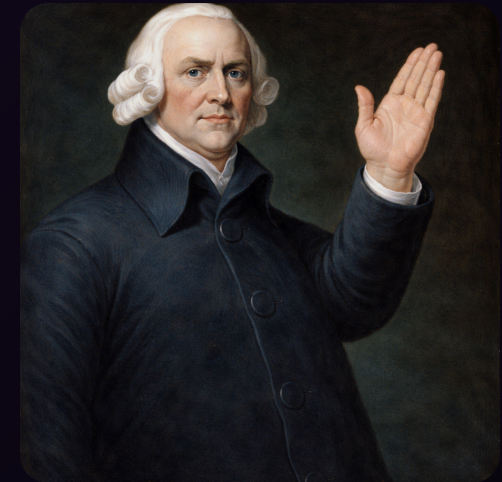
- **1970s** "Sharing culture"
Homebrew Computer Club (pre-open source)
- **1976:** Bill Gates, "An Open Letter to Hobbyists"
"People copying software is stealing"
- **1983:** GNU Project (Richard Stallman)
1985: GNU GPL v1
 - Must share source
 - Keeps software open
 - Requires attribution
- **1987:** MIT License (Massachusetts Institute of Technology)
 - Do anything (even use in closed software)
 - Just keep attribution

Software as knowledge not property

FOSS as the commons

- Bitcoin and Nostr require no permission
- Open protocols keep capital answerable to users
- Adam Smith Invisible Bitch Slap (Ben™)
- Closed platforms lock people in, enshittify, push users to FOSS

Nurture the commons and get rewarded, exploit it and get a slap



The good: vibe coding

BUILD LIKE IT'S 1975 🎵

- Culture of building again
- Gonzo Development (Ben™)
- Cost of producing software is low (allegedly)

Doomer time...

The bad: hype, myth, limitations

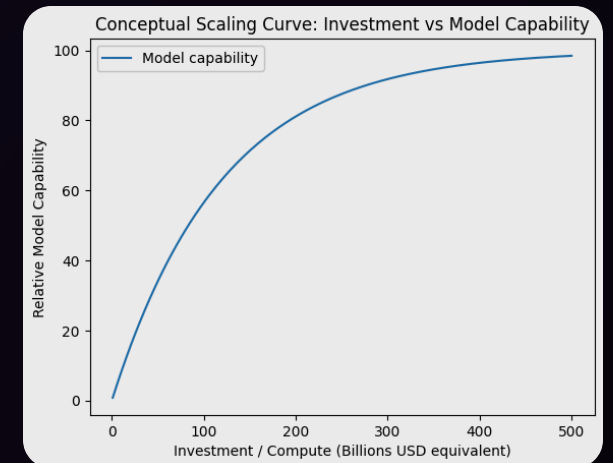
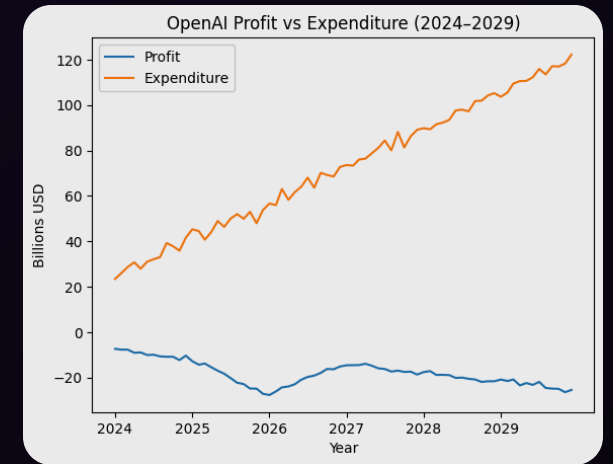
- Licensing implications + code theft
 - Licenses matter!
- !context === slop. Agents get dumb fast
- Turing hype: LLMs are great at sounding clever
- AI hallucinates and is unpredictable
- VC/CEO crack - dump workforce, force useless "AI" products on customers

Risk	Result
License breach	Everyone sues each other
AI over-pumped	Later market correction
Skill atrophy	Bleed engineering talent

The ugly: AI industry is a huge bubble

- Unsustainable AI business models (current 10x discount before profit)
- AGI promise built on sand/assumptions (enough power then AGI)
- Rising energy/resource costs
- Capital intensity problem facing frontier AI companies
- Gov tax breaks
- Slow/expensive infrastructure rollout
- If/when promises are kept capitalism breaks

Risk	Result
Poor AI economics	Users won't pay actual cost
AI plateaus	VCs lose return/hyper-enshittification
Industry buckles under own falsehoods	AI development grinds to a halt



Reality

- Make hay while the sun shines 🧑
- Don't bleed engineers
- Build like it's 1975
- **context, context, context** ideas are scarce, tokens are unrealistically cheap

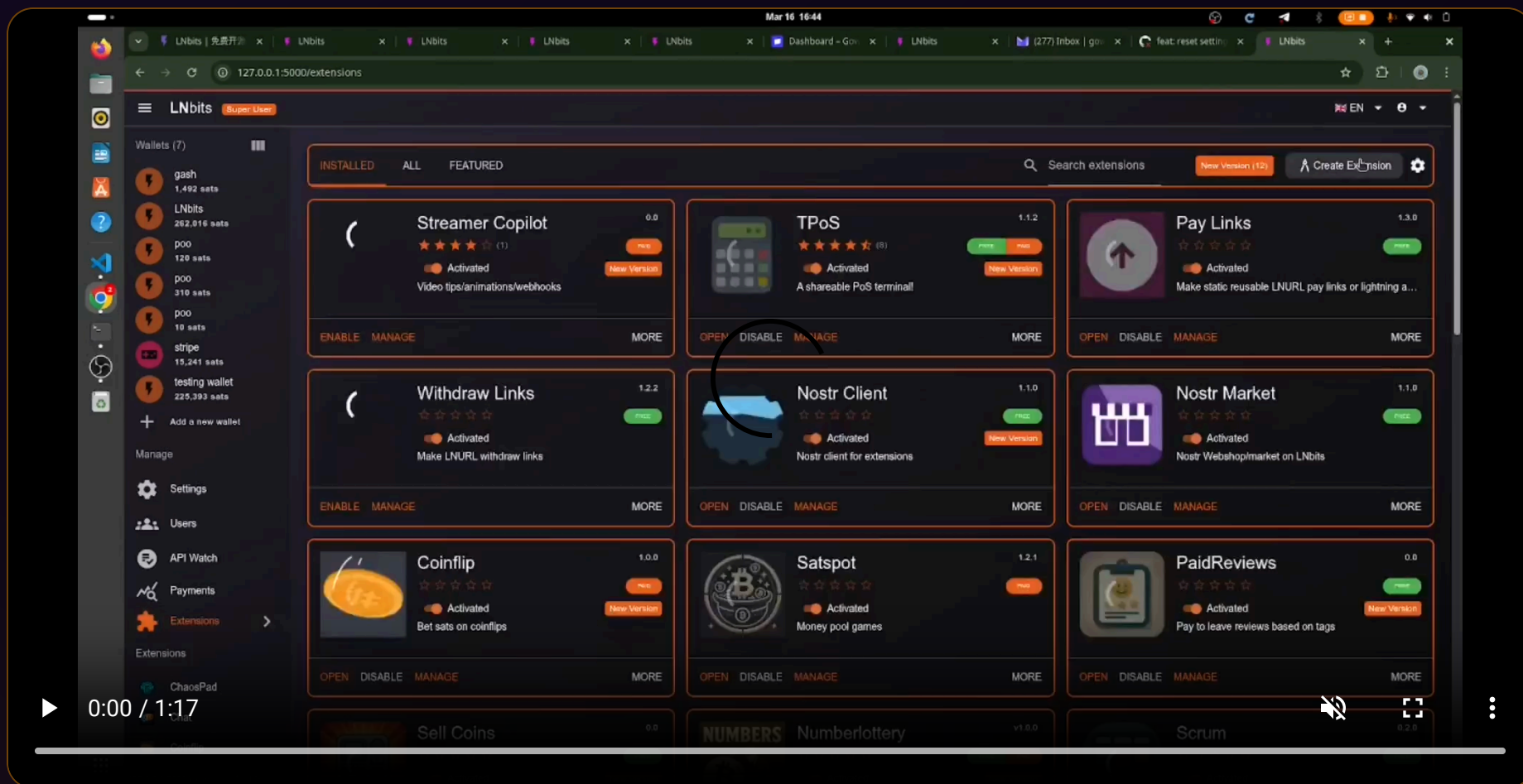
Replacing a developer with AI is like replacing a carpenter with a hammer

Adjusting to current reality

- Some systems should stay dumb, narrow, and predictable
- API is the UI for AI
- Be mindful we are in a blip that could pop
- We still exist in a world of friction, removing friction has value
- Engineers are not paid just to type code
- AI is weak outside the training set
- Humans have material reality context

I still review all the code, AI isn't there yet ~ Dario Amodei





Demo